



A CROWD gathers in the community of Tadamon to watch the expected hanging of militia leader Saleh al-Ras, dubbed “Syria’s Hitler.”

After massacre, a thirst for revenge

The rumored public execution of an Assad enforcer draws wide interest in Syrian suburb

By NABIH BULOS

DAMASCUS, Syria — The crowd surged forward, thousands cheering, waving and jostling their way around Damascus’ Al Ashmar Square, all positioning themselves for the best view of a hanging.

“Hurry up,” a mother scolded her child as they walked along the roadside. “We don’t want to be late.”

A firetruck approached, spurring a chorus of shouts by those thinking a condemned man was inside. Young men scampered onto the truck, hoping to glimpse Saleh al-Ras, an enforcer for former Syrian President Bashar Assad, who was ousted by rebels this month after 13 years of civil war.

Al-Ras led a militia that oversaw security in the district of Tadamon, just outside Damascus, and is widely believed to be responsible for nu-



BONES lie on the ground in Tadamon. Al-Ras, a henchman of ex-Syrian President Bashar Assad, is believed responsible for many atrocities in the area, including a 2013 massacre that killed 300.

merous atrocities there, including a 2013 massacre that killed nearly 300 people. People in Tadamon have a nickname for the toothbrush-mustached henchman: “Syria’s Hitler.”

“This man, he and his people, they were animals,” said Majed Shaaban, 32, who works for a cleaning services company. “I came to see him die.”

Shaaban and the rest of the crowd would eventually leave the square in disappointment.

Syria’s new leaders have promised justice for a population that had been terrorized for decades by a government that imprisoned, disappeared, tortured and killed people and used sexual violence as a weapon of war. But in keeping with the former rebels’ quest for international legitimacy, they have also vowed to deliver that justice through the rule of law, with prosecutions that could

[See Syria, A5]

State plans to continue using gas facility, drawing outcry

Residents, activists want a swifter closure at Aliso Canyon.

By ANDREW J. CAMPA

California regulators voted Thursday to continue using the Aliso Canyon natural gas storage facility

probably into the next decade, over the objection of local activists and residents who demanded a swifter closure of the site of the largest methane leak in U.S. history.

The California Public Utilities Commission voted 4 to 0, with one abstention, in favor of a plan first pitched Nov. 13 to develop a process to wind down the storage fa-

cility as demand for natural gas falls — as is expected in the coming years.

The vote took place in San Francisco, where dozens of people protested outside. Nearly 80 addressed the commission virtually or in person during a 2½-hour public comment period.

“This is not the same as the commission saying that

we do not care about local residents’ concerns,” said CPUC Commissioner John Reynolds. “It means, rather, that we are obligated to ... uphold our core responsibility of ensuring safe, reliable and affordable utility service.”

But that came as little comfort to those who for years have pushed to close

the Southern California Gas Co.-owned storage field in Porter Ranch, which sprang a lengthy leak in late 2015.

“You’re hearing the distress out there that, ‘We waited nine years for this,’” state Sen. Henry Stern (D-Calabasas) said.

The disaster spewed 109,000 tons of methane and

[See Aliso Canyon, A8]

Recruiting ‘wives’ to spread fentanyl across Alaska

California inmate spun a drug web that reached remote corners of the state, officials say



EMILIANO PONZI For The Times

By MATTHEW ORMSETH

As Sunday Powers drove along a remote highway in Alaska, her boss tracked her every move from 3,000 miles away.

A former Girl Scout raised in a town called North Pole, population 2,427, Powers had gotten involved in the drug business. She sold blue fentanyl pills and smuggled money for a dealer in California, according to court documents and interviews.

Powers had never met her boss, Heraclio Sanchez Rodriguez — he had been serving a life sentence in the California prison system since 1998. Authorities charge that Sanchez ran one of the largest drug trafficking organizations in Alaska history without ever setting foot in the state.

Using contraband cellphones, Sanchez spun a web that stretched from Mexico to Los Angeles to far-flung Alaska villages, authorities say. Flights carried women traveling with drugs and cash. Packages stuffed with fentanyl pills flowed through the U.S. postal system. Cash App payments linked senders in Alaska to recipients in Mexicali

[See Sanchez, A4]

Labor effort at LAUSD reaches higher

Overburdened principals and other middle managers vote to join Teamsters.

By HOWARD BLUME

Los Angeles Unified school principals — saying their workload is too heavy and the pressure to raise student achievement, manage complex budgets and keep campuses safe is too intense — have voted to join the Teamsters union in a rebuke to the leadership of Supt. Alberto Carvalho and the Board of Education.

In an election that concluded last week, 85% of voting members, who include principals and other mid-level administrators, chose to unionize. In essence, the leaders of 1,300 public schools in the nation’s second-largest school system — who are known for strict adherence to policies and for echoing the district’s messaging — have said their burden is unfair and their voices go unheard.

“What I hear from the field is people want out, people want to retire early, and they don’t feel supported,” said Maria Nichols, president of Associated Administrators of Los Angeles, the union that already represented school administrators and which conducted the election to affiliate with the Teamsters. “It’s task upon task upon task. They’re overworked and on overload.”

Having the muscle and experience of the Teamsters will make a difference, said Nichols: “People are asking for change, and we knew that if we didn’t do something transformational, we were going to get the same results as last year, which is nothing. Now we’re ready to be able to take the district to collective bargaining.”

Senior district officials, who are not involved in labor organizing, defended their actions, while trying not to stoke the anger of the newly fired-up union.

“Los Angeles Unified is committed to being the district of choice not only for families but also for employees,” according to a district statement. “We strive to provide our workforce with competitive salaries, un-

[See Principals, A10]

House approves spending plan

Bill temporarily funds federal operations and disaster aid but drops Trump’s debt limit demand. **NATION, A6**

Tension over trans athletes

In Riverside, a lawsuit alleging bias against two female runners is dividing the school district. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Are the Bruins still blue bloods?

UCLA men’s basketball team has won just one national championship in the last 50 years. **SPORTS, B12**

Weather

Foggy, then sunny. L.A. Basin: 67/47. **B8**



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